

E6 Decision-Making Autonomy

Rebuilt from scratch. The original offered generic autonomy advice. This version provides a specific decision rights framework.

Pillar	Enablement	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-55 minutes	Group Size	4-10
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	V7 (Reducing Fear of Failure) recommended for safe-to-fail framing	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Lack of autonomy in decision-making, micromanagement signals, decision-making delays, employees not taking initiative, empowerment gaps

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Autonomy is one of the three core psychological needs identified by Self-Determination Theory (Deci & Ryan). When met, it produces sustained intrinsic motivation through dopamine activation. When denied, it produces a specific pattern: compliance without commitment, effort without creativity, and eventual disengagement.

The brain's prefrontal cortex, which handles planning, judgment, and creative thinking, engages fully only when the person believes their decisions matter. If every decision requires approval, the prefrontal cortex learns to disengage: 'Why think carefully about this when someone else will decide anyway?' This is the neurological mechanism behind the complaint that employees 'don't take initiative.' They stopped initiating because the brain learned that initiative wasn't rewarded.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Decision Map (15 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Let's map every decision that gets made in our team's work. Not just the big ones. The daily ones too: how to approach a task, when to escalate, what to prioritise, how to respond to a client. For each decision, I want us to identify: who currently makes it, and who should make it."

Create a decision inventory on the flipchart. For each decision, mark current state:

- Manager decides (team executes)
- Manager approves (team proposes, manager signs off)
- Team decides (manager informed after the fact)

- Individual decides (no approval needed)

Phase 2: The Autonomy Shift (15 minutes)

For each decision currently at 'Manager decides' or 'Manager approves,' ask:

THREE QUESTIONS

1. What's the worst realistic outcome if this person makes this decision without my approval?
2. Is the cost of that worst case greater than the cost of the approval bottleneck?
3. What does this person need (information, training, authority) to make this decision well?

For each decision that should move toward more autonomy, define the shift explicitly:

- From 'Manager decides' to 'Manager approves': the team member proposes, manager signs off
- From 'Manager approves' to 'Team decides': the team member decides, manager is informed
- From 'Team decides' to 'Individual decides': the person owns it completely

Each shift should include: what authority is being transferred, what information the person needs, and what the escalation trigger is ("Come to me if the decision involves more than X budget/Y risk/Z stakeholders").

Phase 3: The Guardrails (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"More autonomy doesn't mean no boundaries. It means clear boundaries that you operate within independently. Let's define the guardrails: what are the non-negotiables where you always need to check with me, and what's the space within which you have full authority?"

Write the guardrails on a single page. Post them visibly. These are the team's decision rights charter.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The manager struggles to let go of any decisions	Start with the lowest-risk decisions: "Pick one decision that, if someone else made it incorrectly, the maximum cost would be an hour of rework. Start there. Build trust incrementally."
A team member says they don't want more decision authority	Explore: "Is that because you don't want the responsibility, or because the consequences of getting it wrong feel too high?" If it's safety, address through V7. If it's genuine preference, respect it while ensuring they're still developing.
Autonomy is granted but	This destroys autonomy faster than never granting it. "If I'm overturning

decisions keep getting overturned	decisions, either the guardrails aren't clear enough or I'm not really delegating. Let's look at what happened and fix the boundary, not the decision."
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Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
E3: Empowerment Through Delegation	E3 transfers tasks. E6 transfers decision authority. Both are needed for genuine empowerment.	Run together
OP11: Project Ownership	Ownership requires decision authority. E6 provides the framework; OP11 provides the project context.	Complementary
V7: Reducing Fear of Failure	Autonomy requires safe-to-fail conditions. V7 establishes the safety; E6 provides the authority.	V7 before E6
V10: Respectful Disagreement	When people have decision authority, disagreements about decisions become more frequent. V10 ensures those disagreements are productive.	Complementary